



Push and pull: France, RN and the challenges of political change

July 3, 2026

France and Europe are moving into the shadow of 2027 presidential elections. In an increasingly geopolitical world, the EU needs to invest, innovate, and acquire strategic autonomy to maintain its relevance. Indebted public balance sheets and a drift towards populism are significant hurdles. The question we ponder is how much higher these hurdles will become when France goes post-Macron.

On [July 7](#), the Court will rule on Marine Le Pen's eligibility to run for President. If Le Pen is barred from running, Jordan Bardella will be [RN's candidate](#) in the election. However, this Court decision will not resolve the fundamental dilemma facing the Rassemblement National (RN). Instead, it is likely to set the stage for **"push and pull"** – a continuous tension between RN's political ambitions and the powerful constraints it would face in government.

While RN may be closer to power than at any point in its history, electoral success and governing capacity are not the same thing. The party's platform would have to contend with a series of powerful constraints – from constitutional guardrails, fiscal realities to market discipline, and demographic trends. Understanding an RN government requires looking not only at what the party wants to do, but also at what it would realistically be able to do.

There are three key points we would make.

1. The potential path to power – Why the Presidency is not enough. We find that RN not only has a credible path to the presidency but also, perhaps unintuitively, to a National Assembly majority and control of the government. This is due to France's legislative electoral system, which creates a significant "majority premium" for the party that finishes first in the national first-round vote. This makes the legislative elections that would follow the presidential contest a critical event for markets. To be sure, RN would not control the entire State apparatus, as both the Senate and Constitutional Council are designed for slow, gradual change, creating durable checks on the government. We also find a core internal tension between Le Pen's traditional base and Bardella's market-friendly wing, a conflict that defines the party's uncertain economic direction.

2. The policy agenda – Part fixed, part pragmatic. The RN is not monolithic, and its evolving platform and attempt to appear more governable could still **collide with hard realities**. This collision is evident in that, for every major policy ambition there is at least one specific constraint, **creating strong incentives for policy pragmatism**: flagship immigration proposals face constitutional blockades and slowing demographics; expensive fiscal promises face market scrutiny; and the party's electoral base acts as a political brake on a full pivot to economic liberalism.

3. Europe – Disruption, not rupture. RN is likely to try to use France's institutional weight within the EU, but we think disruption would be more likely than rupture. While an RN government could generate **significant friction, its ability to alter EU policy could be limited** by internal EU voting rules,

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enforcement mechanisms, and ideological divides with potential right-wing allies.

Ultimately, we think the key issue is not whether the RN can win power, but how France's institutions and economic realities would shape what the party can do with it. In our view, the defining feature of an RN government would likely be the volatility created by a continuous **push and pull** between political ambition and governing reality.

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The possibility of a Rassemblement National (RN) victory in France in 2027 should no longer be considered a tail risk. [Current polling](#) suggests that an RN candidate – whether Marine Le Pen or, if legal developments force a succession, Jordan Bardella – potentially has a credible path to the second round of the presidential election and the Élysée Palace itself. More importantly, for investors, France's institutional calendar means that a RN presidential victory would likely be followed by a snap legislative election, creating a realistic pathway to a parliamentary majority and, thus, meaningful governing power.

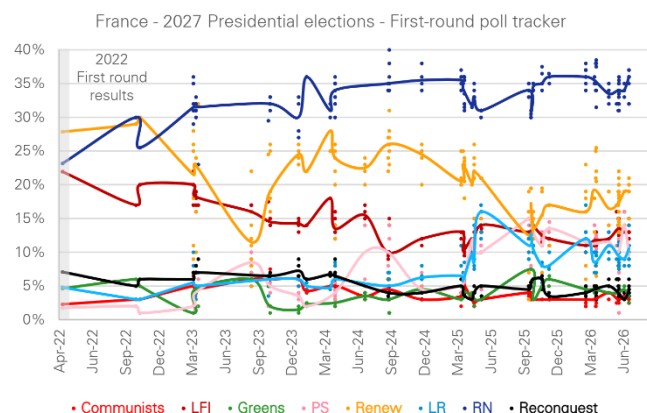
However, in our view the focus should be less on whether RN can win power and more on what it could actually do with it.

The defining characteristic of any RN administration would likely be a continuous tension between political ambition and governing realities. Constitutional constraints, the Senate, EU institutions, fiscal arithmetic, demographic pressures, and financial markets would all act as powerful checks on the implementation of the party's programme. There may be volatility, but disruption appears more likely than rupture.

RN in power never felt as close. Politically, RN is in a stronger position than at any point in its history, with recent polls suggesting either of its likely candidates – Le Pen or Bardella, depending on the outcome of the [July 7](#) court verdict – could win the presidency against any potential opponent. Crucially, the RN also has a credible path to a National Assembly majority. Despite polling in the mid-30s, France's two-round electoral system creates a significant "majority premium" for the leading party, which can translate into control of the government. The key uncertainty, we think, is therefore less RN's ability to reach power but whether a broad anti-RN coalition can re-emerge as it did in 2024.

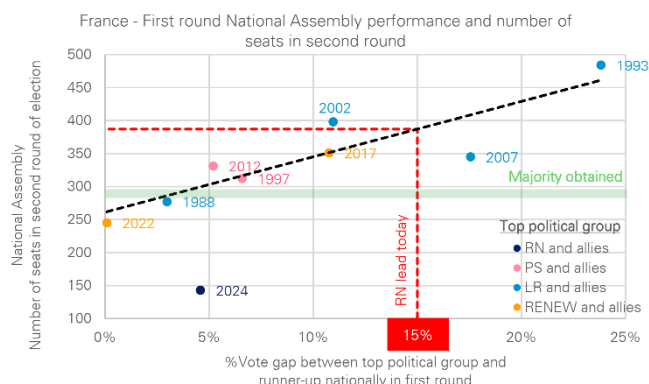


A comfortable lead for the RN candidate, and an open race for the contenders



Deutsche Bank Research, IFOP, Cluster 17, Elabe, Odoxa, Harris Interactive, Opinionway, Verian, IPSOS

Picturing the implied majority premium in French legislative elections

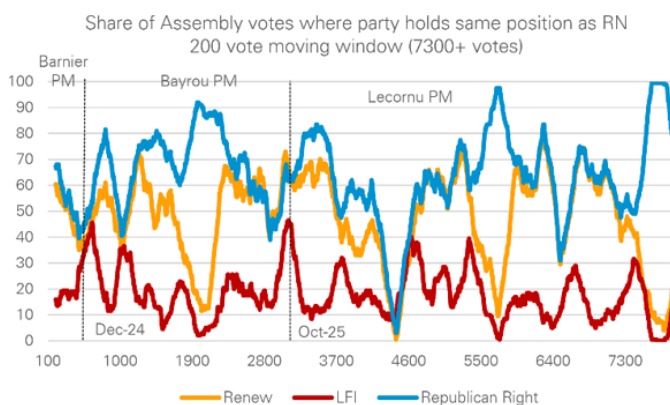
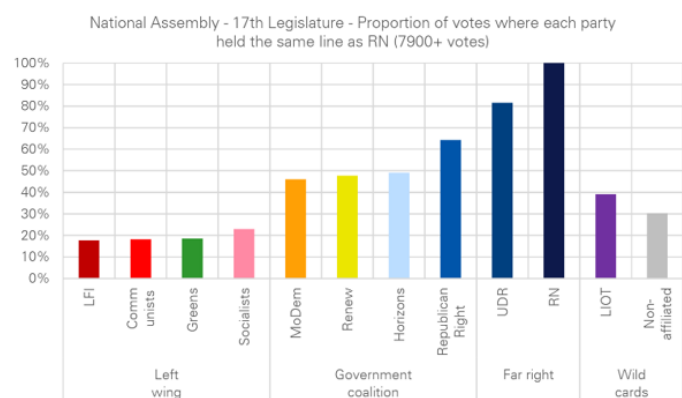


Deutsche Bank Research, French Ministry of the Interior

Current political fragmentation suggests a traditional broad anti-RN coalition is far from certain. However, the party's power would not be absolute: both the Senate and the Constitutional Council are designed for slow, gradual change, creating durable checks on an RN government.

Two-headed RN, debates not settled. A second uncertainty concerns the party itself. While Bardella has increasingly become the public face of RN, Marine Le Pen remains the dominant political figure. The result is a [growing tension](#) between two competing economic narratives. Bardella has sought to reassure investors and business leaders through a more market-friendly, fiscally conservative message, whereas Le Pen's traditional social-sovereigntist approach remains focused on purchasing power, pensions, and economic protection. This ambiguity is important because RN's parliamentary voting record often appears more pragmatic and centre-right than its rhetoric suggests, yet its electoral base remains strongly attached to protective policies.

RN is closer to the centre-right than to any other non-far right party in voting behavior



Deutsche Bank Research, National Assembly. The sample covers all the votes that occurred between October 2024 and July 2026

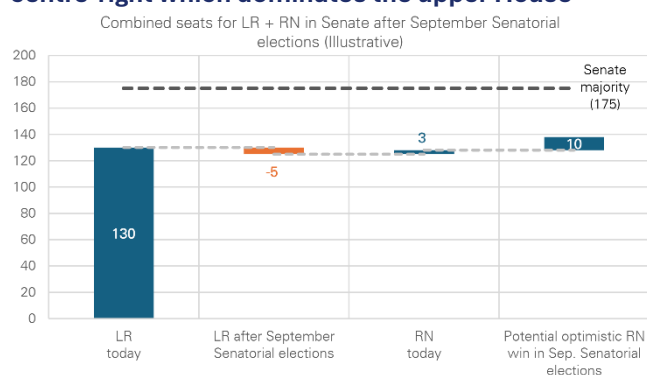
On policy, immigration remains the most stable element of the RN platform, while Europe and pensions have evolved significantly. RN has [effectively abandoned](#) 'Frexit' and euro-exit proposals, opting instead for a **pragmatic** strategy of reshaping the EU from within. Its objective is now to slow further integration, reduce France's net contribution to the EU budget, challenge certain aspects of EU legal primacy, and roll back elements of the Green Deal rather



than leave European institutions altogether. This moderation substantially reduces the systemic risk profile relative to previous electoral cycles but, nevertheless, is likely to create tension.

Material institutional obstacles to full platform implementation. Many of RN's flagship immigration proposals would likely run into constitutional obstacles, according to leading constitutional experts (see [here](#) and [here](#) for details). Measures based on "national preference" appear [difficult to reconcile](#) with France's constitutional principle of equality before the law. The Constitutional Council would likely act as a substantial brake on implementation, while constitutional revision itself would likely face formidable procedural hurdles, particularly given RN's long-term inability to secure meaningful representation in the Senate (for details and seat projections, see [here](#)). In practice, many of the party's most ambitious proposals would probably need to be moderated if they are to become law.

RN's weak footing in the Senate does not facilitate Constitutional reforms, even in an alliance with the centre-right which dominates the upper House



Deutsche Bank Research, French Senate

A standard and a controversial path for Constitutional reform

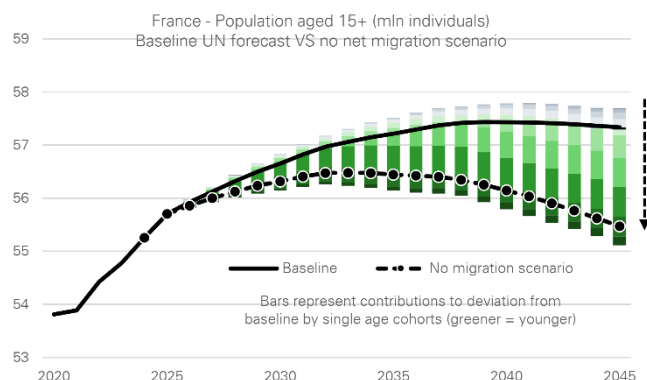
Paths to Constitutional revision for RN			
Path	Key requirement(s)	Main obstacle for RN	Timeline implication
Standard path (Article 89)	Identical text passed by both National Assembly & Senate; then referendum OR 3/5 supermajority of both houses. Referendum mandatory if revision initiated by Parliament	Blocked by opposition-controlled Senate (RN has minimal representation, alliances unlikely to reach majority).	Deliberately slow: Mandatory delays (6 weeks + 4 weeks) for parliamentary debate, lengthy back-and-forth.
Contested path (Article 11)	President calls direct referendum (bypassing Parliament).	Legally contested for constitutional revision, triggers institutional crisis and confrontation with Council/Senate. Restrictions in subjects (only economic policy, public authority organization).	Potentially faster in execution, but the process of navigating the resulting political and legal crisis would be extensive and unpredictable.

Deutsche Bank Research, Constitutional Council

Fiscal policy – Asymmetric spending/saving commitments are a risk. For markets, fiscal policy remains the most important area of focus. RN's programme contains a clear asymmetry between highly visible spending commitments and comparatively uncertain savings plans. Measures aimed at boosting purchasing power, protecting pensions, and reducing energy taxation carry material fiscal costs, while proposed offsets – including lower immigration spending, anti-fraud initiatives and reduced EU contributions – are inherently less predictable. [Independent estimates](#) have suggested that the gap between proposed spending and realistic savings could be substantial.

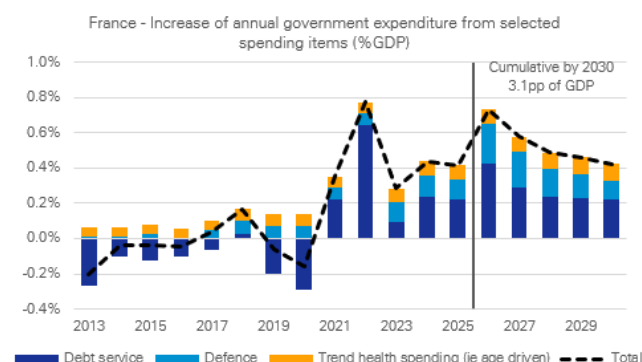
RN would inherit an already fragile fiscal backdrop. France faces elevated public debt, persistent deficits, rising defence requirements, and adverse demographic trends. Lower immigration, while politically central to RN's platform, could further reduce labour-force growth and worsen age-related fiscal pressures over time. Consequently, an RN government would likely face difficult trade-offs between delivering electoral promises, maintaining fiscal credibility, and supporting growth.

Less immigration, more adverse demographics



Deutsche Bank Research, French Senate

Meaningful upward pressure on government spending every year



Deutsche Bank Research, Constitutional Council

Careful policy calibration needed to avoid a market challenge. Financial markets therefore represent one of the most immediate constraints. Unlike constitutional or political obstacles, market discipline can emerge quickly. Any perception that an RN government is unwilling or unable to stabilise the fiscal trajectory could lead to higher sovereign risk premia, rising debt-servicing costs and tighter domestic financial conditions. With debt sustainability already a vulnerability, France can ill-afford to lose more fiscal credibility. Any fiscal misstep could quickly face sharp market scrutiny. The question is how pragmatic RN would be in response.

Momentum for EU strategic autonomy and integration at risk. At the European level, we think the most likely scenario is increased friction. France has considerable weight within the EU, and an RN administration could slow integration, complicate negotiations on EU budgets, enlargement or defence initiatives, and create uncertainty around France's future role in European policymaking. Yet, the ability to fundamentally alter EU outcomes would remain constrained by voting rules, enforcement mechanisms, and the difficulty of assembling durable alliances across Europe's fragmented right.

Different shades of right in the European Parliament

European Parliament - Right-wing groups political profiles			
	European Conservatives and Reformists (ECR)	Patriots for Europe (Pfe)	Europe of Sovereign Nations (ESN)
Number of MEPs	Right-wing 82	85	Extreme Right 27
Top-3 member parties	- Brothers of Italy (24 MEPs) - Polish PIS (20) - Romanian AUR (6)	- French National Rally (29 MEPs) - Hungarian Fidesz (11) - Italian League (7)	- German AfD (15 MEPs) - Bulgarian Revival (3) - Polish Konfederacja (2)
Political profile	- Partly Eurosceptic - Pro-Ukraine and NATO - Anti Green deal - Anti immigration	- Eurosceptic, similar to previous "Identity and Democracy" group - Russia-friendly and NATO sceptic - Anti Green deal - Anti immigration	- Eurosceptic - Russia-friendly and NATO sceptic - Anti Green deal - Anti immigration

Deutsche Bank Research, European Parliament



Bottom line. Our conclusion is nuanced. An RN victory would represent a significant political event, but France's institutional architecture makes revolutionary change difficult. The most probable outcome in our view would be elevated uncertainty, periodic clashes with domestic and European institutions, and selective policy shifts rather than a wholesale restructuring of the French economic model. For financial markets, we believe the key theme is not outright regime change, but a constant, volatility-inducing push and pull between RN's political objectives – shifting in places – and the fiscal, legal, and market constraints that would ultimately shape its capacity to govern. The push for political change will generate friction.



Appendix 1

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